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The Influence of Spirituality on Buyer Perception Within Business-to-Business Marketing Relationships: A Cross-Cultural Exploration and Comparison

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Within business-to-business relationship marketing, boundary-spanning representatives play a crucial role in establishing and maintaining positive relations between their organizations. Spirituality, a workplace individual-level variable, is proposed to significantly influence buyer representatives' relationship formation with their seller counterparts, which subsequently affects the relationship development between organizations. Here we identify aspects of spirituality within buyer representatives and present a conceptual framework that delineates the impact of spirituality upon individual perceptions of relational constructs such as trust and commitment. Structural equation modeling analyses support the inclusion of spirituality as a relevant construct in relationship marketing research. In addition, because cultural differences are known to exist regarding the role of spirituality, the impact of spirituality upon perception within relationship marketing is addressed with data collected from both American and Chinese buying representatives. The results indicate that spirituality is significantly related to

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perceptions about communication, commitment, and shared values for both sets of participants.

KEYWORDS *business to business, relationship marketing, spirituality*

Since Jackson (1985) first made the distinction between transaction marketing and relationship marketing (RM) in business-to-business interactions, the idea of RM has increasingly become a topic of interest to marketers and researchers alike. RM is a social process between organizations; frequently, however, the primary (if not sole) contact between organizations is in the form of the boundary-spanning buyers and sellers who interact with each other on behalf of their organizations (Crosby, Evans, & Cowles, 1990; McKee, 2003). These individuals play a pivotal role in establishing trust and commitment between organizations, building and maintaining the foundation for a strong, successful business-to-business relationship. RM researchers have echoed this sentiment, noting that representatives from both buying and selling organizations are “key actors” building ties with their counterparts (Swan & Nolan, 1985, p. 39).

Consequently, the personalities and values of the individuals who establish and maintain these interpersonal relationships are worthy of examination. These employees develop social relationships that extend the contractual nature of interorganizational interactions and strengthen interorganizational relationships through deeper, richer forms of trust than strictly transactional agreements (Guenzi & Pelloni, 2004; Hakansson & Snehota, 2000). In fact, Palmatier, Dant, Grewal, and Evans (2006) found the relational characteristics of the salesperson created a stronger link between a customer’s judgment and outcomes than did the characteristics of the selling firm. Thus, RM representatives warrant further investigation. Specifically, the individual-level constructs that influence employee perceptions with regard to established RM key constructs such as trust and commitment have yet to be fully explored.

In this article, our focus is on one of these potential influencers in an RM context—a buyer’s *spirituality*. As an individual difference variable, spirituality has received considerable attention recently in the organizational literature, particularly as it relates to working relationships. As we discuss, spirituality affects a person’s perception of self, others, and relationships. By extending the working relationships metaphor to interorganizational marketing relationships, we explore how a buyer’s spirituality affects perceptions of trust and commitment in marketing relationships and interactions with sellers. It is our contention that this individual characteristic may serve to expand relationship marketers’ understanding of a vital antecedent to the formation of trust and commitment in marketing relationships.

In addition to examining spirituality within an interorganizational marketing relationship, this study also explores the effects of spirituality from a cross-cultural perspective. Much of the organizational research conducted on spirituality has been from a predominantly Western perspective and/or context (Ashmos & Duchon, 2000; Jurkiewicz & Giacalone, 2004; Marques, Dhiman, & King, 2005; Milliman, Czaplewski, & Ferguson, 2003; Mitroff & Denton, 1999). However, researchers now call for studies that explore whether individual spirituality differences measured from a Western mind-set generalize to a non-Western culture (Benefiel, 2003; Piedmont & Leach, 2002).

The purpose of this study is therefore twofold: first, to present a conceptual framework that delineates the impact of spirituality upon individual buyer perceptions of relational constructs such as trust and commitment in marketing relationships; and second, to compare this effect cross-culturally. To accomplish these objectives, we first provide a brief overview of spirituality research, noting in particular the literature on *workplace* spirituality. Next we present a conceptual framework that outlines the theoretical relationship of spirituality to trust and commitment as well as to other established constructs in the extant RM literature likely influenced by spirituality, namely communication, shared values, and opportunism. Through path modeling we evaluate our framework and determine the relevancy of spirituality as an RM construct. We offer results involving buyers from both America and China that compare the role of spirituality across the two cultures, as well as results of hierarchical regression analyses conducted to test for mediating effects. Finally, we summarize and reflect upon our findings and delineate their theoretical and managerial implications, as well as offer suggestions for future research.

SPIRITUALITY RESEARCH

In the 20th century, William James and other psychological researchers related spirituality to a person's character or disposition and linked it to the subsequent actions of that person (Miller & Thoresen, 2003). Over time, the distinction between religion and spirituality has been addressed, particularly in Western cultures such as the United States (Koenig, McCullough, & Larson, 2001); this is evident in the psychological literature, in which the term *spirituality* is increasingly used to refer to the personal, subjective side of religious experience (Hill & Pargament, 2003). Despite a growing body of spirituality research, a generally accepted definition of the concept remains elusive (Gotsis & Kortezi, 2008). With that said, the elements of meaningfulness, inner wholeness, and connectedness to others are common threads that have characterized researchers' conceptualization of spirituality to date (King, 1997; Mitroff, 2003).

Distinguishing Between Spirituality and Religion

When discussing spirituality, the role of religion and the extent to which it is considered an independent construct from spirituality must be addressed. Miller and Thoresen (2003) provided an interesting analogy by saying that the field of religion is to spirituality as the field of medicine is to health. Some researchers (Delbecq, 1999; Hicks, 2003) believe spirituality to be intimately associated with religious-based faith traditions. In contrast, other researchers conceptualize spirituality as an independent construct separate from any religious context (Mitroff, 2003; Zinnebauer & Paragament, 2005). Gotsis and Kortezi (2008) described spirituality as a universally held view not tied to any one faith, a concept that supports an emphasis on value systems and community building yet retains an element of transcendence. In non-Western cultures, spirituality often represents a personal concern for moral well-being, whereas religion is indicative of beliefs or practices of a particular faith or tradition (Ho & Ho, 2007; Paranjpe, 1988).

Our study aligns with the conceptualization of spirituality as a construct distinctly separate from religion. Although we acknowledge the relatedness of spirituality and religion, we agree that spirituality is universal in its orientation and uncoupled from any one specific religious doctrine (Duchon & Ashmos Plowman, 2005; Gotsis & Kortezi, 2008). Ho and Ho (2007) believe that spirituality is observable in a person's work, and indeed a large body of spirituality research is devoted to the topic of spirituality within the workplace context, to which we now turn.

Workplace Spirituality

Hicks (2003) charted the interest in spirituality research within a workplace context back to the 1980s. However, its presence as a construct in both the academic and practitioner organizational behavior literatures has increased significantly in recent years because of increased competition, downsizing, and the fact that work has become a primary source of community and identity for workers (Cartwright & Cooper, 1997; Milliman et al., 2003; Shellenbarger, 2000). Regardless, workplace spirituality researchers note the lack of one established definition (Ashforth & Pratt, 2003; Tischler, Biberman, & McKeage, 2002). Gotsis and Kortezi (2008) found no dominant paradigm or prevailing framework within the workplace spirituality literature, citing Milliman et al.'s observations that as a construct spirituality is complex and multifaceted. There is a call for additional research regarding the outcomes of individual-level spirituality in the workplace (Mohamed, Wisnieski, Askar, & Syed, 2004), and such individual-level outcomes are the focus of the present study.

At the individual level, "workplace spirituality" entails the desire of people to convey aspects of their being at work and to be engaged in work they consider meaningful (Kinjerski & Skrypnik, 2004). Kinjerski and Skrypnik

described the phenomenon as a holistic experience in which individuals share a sense of interconnectedness and an alignment between their values and actions. Neck and Milliman (1994) defined *workplace spirituality* as both the desire to find meaning and purpose and the process of living out one's personal values.

Despite the lack of one agreed-upon conceptualization, key elements of spirituality have emerged in the extant research that inform our conceptualization of the construct. For instance, deKlerk (2005) focused on the aspect *meaning*, whereas Marques (2007), Milliman et al. (2003), and Mitroff and Denton (1999) emphasized both a sense of meaning and connectedness with others. With regard to interconnectedness and interactions with others, researchers have discussed the importance of mutuality, reciprocity, and positive social relations (Kurth, 2003; Marques, 2006; Pfeffer, 2003). Duchon and Ashmos Plowman (2005, p. 625), in their summary of the literature, identified what they called "three fundamental spiritual needs": meaning, purpose, and being connected to others. Based on this summary and the previous literature, we base our conceptualization of individual workplace spirituality on these three fundamental aspects and define *spirituality* as the personal belief in an inner life that seeks to find meaning and purpose nurtured through meaningful work, to perform actions congruent to one's personal values, and to promote a sense of connectedness or community within the context of that work. In the section that follows, we provide further clarification of this construct and its primary aspects.

Aspects of Spirituality

As Dwyer, Schurr, and Oh (1987) noted, interpersonal relationships matter, and successful RM relies on the interpersonal give-and-take between buyer and seller representatives. How successful these interactions are depends in part on individual perceptions and values. It is therefore prudent to identify elements of these individuals' spiritual perspectives that might affect trust building and relationship strengthening. In this section, we delineate three such aspects of spirituality as conceptualized in this study: (a) the recognition of one's inner life; (b) the desire for meaningful work; and (c) the importance of benevolent, honest relationships with colleagues that stress interconnectedness and trust building.

INNER LIFE

Ashmos and Duchon (2000) described inner life as a need within individuals to understand and find purpose and value in themselves. Within a work context, it refers to finding ways to nourish one's own inner life and use one's abilities and positive traits to make a difference in a job and in interactions with others. Inner life speaks to the development and expression of

one's inner self at work (Ashmos & Duchon, 2000), reminiscent of the "self-actualization" stage of Maslow's (1943) hierarchy of needs. The desire for purpose and the need to make a real contribution in order to enrich the inner life can influence and possibly bolster relationship formation, as individuals strive to exhibit that purpose through connectedness with others in the course of their work. Furthermore, individuals with an awareness and appreciation for such a connection (Kurth, 2003) are able to act in ways congruent with that awareness, manifesting in increased trust, honesty, and reciprocity.

MEANINGFUL WORK

The wish to perform meaningful work appears in the past organizational literature as motivation and satisfaction; theories about intrinsic motivation, job design, and needs have promoted the idea of a work environment that encourages and allows for meaningful work among employees. Meaningful work refers to the extent to which employees feel their actions at work are consequential, important, or purposeful; it represents how individuals interact and function at work daily (Milliman et al., 2003). Employees who value meaningful work as a spiritual attribute experience long-term benefits such as satisfaction. For example, Komala and Ganesh (2007) found that individual spirituality manifested at work increased intrinsic job satisfaction.

INTERCONNECTEDNESS WITH OTHERS

In addition to finding meaning and purpose with regard to one's own life and work, the basic desire to feel connected to others, to be part of a community or team, is worth noting, particularly within the context of RM. A spiritual person seeks to create interconnectedness through communication with others; to form meaningful, positive, long-term relationships with individuals that constitute his or her network or community; and to promote mutual benefits for relational partners of that community. In a way, this aspect is similar to stakeholder theory, in that it entails a perception that people involved in a work-related task (e.g., "stakeholders") should be treated as valuable and as an "end" in and of themselves versus being perceived as strictly a means to an end (McKee, 2003). As such, we propose that relationship formation can be enriched through this spiritual desire for interconnectedness.

In summary, spirituality researchers such as Ashmos and Duchon (2000) and Milliman et al. (2003) have conceptualized spirituality as encompassing the three aspects just described. Furthermore, researchers have argued that, although multifaceted, spirituality is best described as a holistic experience (Kinjerski & Skrypnek, 2004). Hence, we conceptualize spirituality as a holistic concept containing the elements of inner life, meaningful work, and interconnectedness with others. We theorize that these aspects of spirituality interact with one another, collectively defining RM

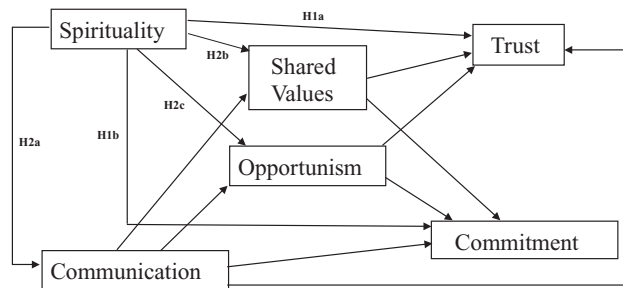


FIGURE 1 Conceptual Model. H = hypothesis.

representatives' spirituality, which in turn influences their perspective on and subsequent approach to work-related interactions with others. In the next section, we present our conceptual framework.

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

Figure 1 presents the conceptual model identifying the relationship of spirituality to trust, commitment, and other relational antecedents. As illustrated in Figure 1, spirituality, communication, shared values, and opportunism are the antecedents of trust and commitment. Here we present a series of hypotheses representing each relationship in the framework.

The Effect of Spirituality on Trust

Trust is the confidence one party has in another party's integrity and reliability and is an underpinning of collaboration (Flores & Solomon, 1998; Morgan & Hunt, 1994; Nicholson, Compeau, & Sethi, 2001; Wicks, Berman, & Jones, 1999). Researchers often refer to trust as a global, unidimensional construct encompassing such things as emotions, values, and morals (Kasper-Fuehrer & Ashkanasy, 2001; Lewicki, Tomlinson, & Gillespie, 2006).

Trust is a well-established construct in the RM literature, as researchers realize the importance trust plays in the relationship-building process (Morgan & Hunt, 1994). Similarly, researchers also note the role key individuals play with regard to their beliefs and actions. In their overview of trust building, Swan and Nolan (1985) described the importance of a representative's personality and behavior in facilitating and developing trust. Similarly, Doney and Cannon (1997) found that trust in a firm's salesperson has a positive effect on trust in the firm. In contrast, Lewicki et al. (2006) showed that a dishonest representative might damage or jeopardize a trusting relationship between organizations.

Trust is dependent on individual perceptions of motives and intentions. It is often operationalized as the extent to which one party can rely on another to behave in a fashion that demonstrates a genuine interest in achieving mutual gain (Ganesan, 1994; Kumar, Scheer, & Steenkamp, 1995; Nicholson et al., 2001). Trust is contingent on the extent to which a person has “trusting beliefs” (beliefs that others will be honest) and “trusting intentions” (a willingness to depend on others; McKnight, Cummings, & Chervany, 1998; Nicholson et al., 2001).

If trust in interorganizational relationships is indeed affected by an individual's actions, it suggests that aspects of a person that mold basic views on integrity, honesty, and reliability should influence that person's perceptions of trust. Spiritual people seek to nourish their inner life through engaging in meaningful actions and by finding opportunities to express spiritual aspects of their being (Ashmos & Duchon, 2000); thus, spirituality is manifested in an individual's behavior through honesty and a respect for others. Therefore, a person's degree of spirituality positively impacts the extent to which that person is likely to trust (Kurth, 2003; Marques, 2006). Spirituality influences the extent to which a person believes well in others, and this belief is expressed through outcomes such as trust (Krishnakumar & Neck, 2002). For that reason, spirituality should strengthen a buyer's trust, as he or she should be inclined to believe in the integrity and goodwill of the organizational counterpart in a marketing relationship.

H1a: Higher levels of buyer spirituality will correspond to higher levels of reported trust toward organizational partners in a marketing relationship.

The Effect of Spirituality on Commitment

Commitment is a pledge (implicit or explicit) of relational stability between partners (Dwyer et al., 1987). The significance of commitment is a common theme in the organizational research on relationships. Researchers view commitment as a foundation of successful relationships and a key to achieving positive outcomes for all parties (Berry & Parasuraman, 1991; Morgan & Hunt, 1994; Stanko, Bonner, & Calantone, in press). According to Lehtonen (2006), successful collaborative relationships depend in part on partners' attitudes; instead of self-seeking behavior, these individuals must exhibit mutual trust, commitment, and openness in the relationship. This illustrates the emotional component of commitment and, just as with trust, means that individuals can have an impact on the extent to which commitment occurs and continues. A spiritual person who values himself or herself by finding meaningful work that is interconnected with others will seek and ultimately be more successful in establishing long-term, committed relationships.

H1b: Higher levels of buyer spirituality will correspond to higher levels of reported commitment to the marketing relationship.

The Effect of Spirituality on Other Relational Antecedents

In addition to spirituality, we include three other relational antecedents found by other RM researchers to affect trust and commitment: (a) communication, (b) shared values, and (c) opportunism. We chose to include these antecedents for a number of reasons. Most important, we expect a certain amount of convergent validity to exist among these three relational constructs and the construct of spirituality. In other words, the basic tenets of spirituality delineated previously relate well to the need for communication, a desire for shared values, and an avoidance of opportunism. In addition, we wish to extend the current spirituality research by examining this construct's impact on variables already established as crucial to relationship formation.

COMMUNICATION

Communication is the formal and informal sharing of information among parties (Morgan & Hunt, 1994), and the sharing of information within the context of interorganizational relationships should be meaningful and reliable (J. A. Anderson & Narus, 1990; Crosby et al., 1990; Putnam & Poole, 1987). Such communication commonly occurs between boundary-spanning buyers and sellers charged with building and maintaining these relationships.

As mentioned previously, a basic tenet of spirituality is the desire for interconnectedness between individuals and the people associated with their work, creating a sense of community. This suggests that a representative who places an importance on spirituality and interconnectedness will be inclined to engage in activities such as frequent, meaningful communication with people in that representative's "work community." For boundary-spanners engaged in marketing relationships with other organizations, that community extends to include their counterparts from other organizations.

Furthermore, in the continued effort to sustain and nourish the inner life and to act in ways congruent with the sacred, spirituality promotes the desire to be honest and to create mutual gains for all parties. Given this, it is reasonable to suggest that a buyer who places an importance on spirituality will value communication that is meaningful and honest and hence be more inclined to engage in such meaningful communication.

H2a: Higher levels of buyer spirituality will correspond positively to buyer perceptions of open communication within marketing relationships.

SHARED VALUES

Shared values refer to the fundamental beliefs and/or values partners have in common with regard to goals, behaviors, and policies (Morgan & Hunt, 1994; Nicholson et al., 2001). Researchers have found shared values to be an

influential component of both trust and commitment in relationships (Dwyer et al., 1987; Palmatier et al., 2006). In the context of marketing relationships, this applies at both the organizational and the individual levels. In the case of individual boundary-spanners, shared values have been shown to increase likeability (e.g., feelings of friendliness; the belief that a person is “nice”; Doney & Cannon, 1997; Lewicki & Bunker, 1995).

Although spirituality in and of itself does not guarantee shared values between individuals, it does increase the likelihood that a person will behave in ways that *promote* shared values. For instance, because workers who demonstrate higher levels of spirituality seek to experience feelings of connectedness with others, this enhances their degree of mutuality and reciprocity (Marques, 2006), thereby increasing the potential to discover and create shared values with the other party.

H2b: Higher levels of buyer spirituality will correspond positively to buyer perceptions of shared values with the seller.

OPPORTUNISM

In contrast to communication and shared values, opportunism has a negative effect on relationships (Morgan & Hunt, 1994). Defined as self-interest seeking with guile (Lee, Pae, & Wong, 2001; Williamson, 1975), *opportunism* is associated with deceitful behavior such as misrepresentation, cheating, and manipulation (E. Anderson, 1988; John, 1984; Lee et al., 2001). Past research shows that a desire for mutual gains and cooperation and a long-term orientation to the relationship lead to less opportunistic behavior (Dwyer et al., 1987; Ganesan, 1994; Parvatiyar & Sheth, 2000). This suggests that a person who places importance on spirituality is less likely to engage in behavior perceived as opportunistic; to do so would be to deny one's inner life and the sacred. The aspects of spirituality that stress honesty, meaning, community building, and the desire to achieve collaborative benefits over the long-term all work to diminish the likelihood of opportunistic behavior in marketing relationships.

H2c: Opportunism will be negatively related to buyer spirituality.

Spirituality and Cross-Cultural Expectations

Past research investigating international contexts and individual differences (e.g., Hofstede, 2001) suggests that spirituality manifests differently across cultures. Thus, we wished to examine the extent to which the Western concept of spirituality generalizes to a culture recognized as distinctly different from that of the United States. Based on previous findings (Hofstede, 2001), we determined China to be a suitable cultural counterpart for our study.

The cultures of the United States and China differ, particularly on the dimension of individualism versus collectivism. The extent to which a culture stresses individualism or collectivism would affect an individual's spirituality, given its emphasis upon community and the value of an individual's inner life. The foundational assumption of individualistic cultures is that individuals are independent from one another (Oyserman, Coon, & Kimmelmeier, 2002). Individualistic cultures therefore stress independence, and ties between people are usually loose (Hofstede, 2001). In contrast, the foundational assumption of collectivist cultures is that groups "bind and mutually obligate individuals" (Oyserman et al., 2002, p. 3). Collectivists tend to divide people into categories of in- and out-groups and stress an orientation toward in-groups and away from out-groups (viewing most business partners as outsiders; Oyserman, 1993; Triandis, 1989; Wang, 2007).

The United States is an individualistic culture; in fact, Hofstede (2001) found individualism to be the highest scoring dimension for that culture. The Chinese culture is typically shown by researchers to be collectivist (Hofstede, 2001; Huff & Kelley, 2003). Thus, relationships are perceived differently in the Chinese mindset than in that of their U.S. counterparts; specifically, the Chinese make distinctions between relationships involving in-group members (e.g., family and relatives) and out-group members (e.g., business partners) that are dissimilar from those of U.S. individuals. In their study of Chinese buyer and seller organizations, A. Wong, Tjosvold, and Yu (2005) found that Chinese partners prepared to exploit those considered out-group members. Other researchers have also noted the tendency of collectivists to be competitive and aggressive toward out-group members, such as members of other organizations (C. C. Chen, Peng, & Saporito, 2002; Triandis, 1990).

The way in which relationships form and develop may also be different across these two cultures. Researchers have found established differences in the manner in which Western and Chinese cultures create and conduct business relationships. In China, various types of "ties" categorize interpersonal relationships. An "expressive tie" is formed only with family and persons within a closed, intimate circle, whereas relationships with "outsiders" are known as "instrumental ties" (Wang, 2007; Y. H. Wong & Chan, 1999). Most interorganizational buyer-seller interactions for business relationships are considered instrumental ties. Such classification is not evident in American business relationships.

The United States and China also differ in the extent to which they trust. The United States is known as a "high-trust" culture, whereas China is a "low-trust" culture (Atuahene-Gima & Li, 2002; X-P. Chen & Chen, 2004). Finally, although religious beliefs tend to differ between the two cultures, spiritual awareness is present and recognized in both cultures. This is important, because we wish to use participants that allow for religious distinction yet still permit us to test for the generalizability of spirituality.

Hence, there is a fundamental difference between the two cultures with regard to relationship formation and ongoing interaction among business partners. To test for these differences, we generate path analyses guided by the aforementioned hypotheses for both U.S. and Chinese data samples. This allows comparative conclusions to be drawn between the resultant findings.

Relational Antecedents and Their Effect on Trust and Commitment

Although our interest lies in the impact of spirituality upon trust and commitment, we recognize the influence of other relational antecedents, including communication, shared values, and opportunism, on marketing relationships. Thus, we include these three constructs in our model in order to provide a more comprehensive representation of the phenomenon. Because the effect of these constructs on trust and commitment (and on one another) is well established in the extant literature (J. A. Anderson & Narus, 1990; John, 1984; Morgan & Hunt, 1994; Nicholson et al., 2001; Palmatier et al., 2006; Parvatiyar & Sheth, 2000), we do not present formal hypotheses for these relationships. They are included in the testing of the conceptual model and summarized in our overall results. Next we present our method of data collection and a description of the included measures, followed by a report of the results.

METHODOLOGY

Data Collection

Our sample represents U.S. and Chinese buyer representatives actively involved in marketing relationships on behalf of their organizations. U.S. participants were located using a commercially available list and asked to complete a mailed survey. Approximately 800 survey requests were mailed; a total of 136 U.S. buyer representatives participated by completing the survey. Thus, our response rate for U.S. participants was 17%. In China, the study was conducted using convenience samples. We collected data from two sources: (a) graduate students of a large Chinese university's Executive Master's of Business Administration program, most of whom had had previous buyer experience in various industries; and (b) buyer representatives working in a variety of industries, such as banking, manufacturing, consulting, and telecommunication services. Overall, 104 Chinese participants completed the survey. A Chinese version of the survey was developed using forward-backward translation techniques and reviewed for accuracy by native speakers. The use of buyer representatives as participants for our study is appropriate because of their intimate knowledge and personal experience in buyer-supplier marketing relationships. These buyer representatives answered survey questions assessing their interactions with key sellers in specific marketing relationships.

MEASURES

The measures used in this study were all adaptations of existing measures in the literature. (We provide sample items for each variable in the Appendix.) Spirituality was measured using questions adapted from Ashmos and Duchon's (2000) spirituality scale and questions regarding "sense of community" from a scale in Milliman et al. (2003). Questions targeted the three spiritual aspects described previously. When necessary, the wording of the questions was adapted to reflect the interorganizational nature of the relationships to which the participants would be referring.

Trust was measured using an adaptation of Morgan and Hunt's (1994) measure of interorganizational trust. Likewise, we assessed commitment using items from Morgan and Hunt's measure for interorganizational relationships. We derived our opportunistic behavior scale from John (1984). Communication and shared values were measured using scales from Sin, Tse, Yau, Lee, and Chow (2002). For all measures, we used a 6-point Likert-type scale to avoid neutral answers and anchored questions with *strongly disagree/strongly agree*.

Analyses

The EQS for Windows program was used for analyses. To test our framework, we used a two-stage data analysis approach as suggested by J. C. Anderson and Gerbing (1988). We first conducted a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) to test measurement validity, followed by a structural path analysis to test our hypotheses. It should be noted that we performed the CFA with the U.S. data sample first and then tested measurement invariance across the U.S. and Chinese samples, which we discuss later in this section.

SECOND-ORDER CFA

We first performed a second-order CFA using the U.S. data sample. Specifically, in the CFA model, spirituality was examined as a second-order factor, whereas inner life, meaningful work, and community were included as first-order factors. The elliptical reweighted least squares procedure was used, given the performance of this procedure with regard to normal and non-normal data and because an assumption of normality is rarely met with these types of constructs (Mohr & Sohi, 1995; Sharma, Durvasula, & Dillon, 1989; Zou & Cavusgil, 2002). The chi-square test was significant, $\chi^2(387) = 614.885$, $p < .001$. Because at least three problems have been identified with the chi-square test (i.e., unknown power, inadequate measurement of goodness of fit, and sensitivity to sample size), additional model fit indices were evaluated as recommended by Bagozzi and Yi (1988). The model exhibited a good fit: comparative fit index (CFI) = .956, Incremental Fit Index

(IFI) = .956, Bentler-Bonett Normed Fit Index (BBNFI) = .950. The standardized factor loadings of all of the items were found to be positive, high in magnitude, and statistically significant. These findings combined indicated that the internal structure of the CFA model was acceptable (J. C. Anderson & Gerbing, 1988).

MEASUREMENT INVARIANCE

To ascertain that our measures were not culture bound, we examined the cross-national equivalence of the measurement model. Two-group CFA was performed to assess measurement invariance across the two samples (Bagozzi & Yi, 1988). The factor structure is specified as invariant across both samples. At least one of the factor loadings across the two groups has to be constrained to be equal (i.e., same values for one item loading across countries) to achieve partial factor structure equivalence (Netemeyer, Durvasula, & Lichtenstein, 1991). A chi-square difference test was performed between the two-group model without constraints and the model with partial constraints (six factor loadings were constrained to be equal). The chi-square difference between two models was 6.652 with 6 degrees of freedom (*ns* at $p < .05$): model without constraints, $\chi^2(774) = 1,249.179$; model with partial constraints, $\chi^2(780) = 1,255.831$. As the two models did not exhibit significant difference in terms of fit, partial measurement invariance was achieved. Furthermore, our analysis revealed that the overall fit of the model with partial constraints yielded adequate fit (CFI = .931, IFI = .932, BBNFI = .923).

COMMON METHOD VARIANCE TEST

We performed Harman's one-factor test to examine common method bias. Because more than one single factor emerged from the factor analysis and no general factor accounted for the majority of the covariance in the variables, common method bias did not appear to be an issue.

Testing Our Model for U.S. and Chinese Data Samples

Similar to the CFA process discussed earlier, we followed the multistep procedure recommended by Bagozzi and Yi (1988) to assess the fit of the path model to the data. Factor scores were computed as a composite of their respective items, which is the most frequently used method to compute factor scores in the *Journal of Marketing Research* and *Journal of Consumer Research* (Lastovicaka & Thamodaran, 1991). The path model was tested with the U.S. data sample first and then the Chinese sample. Table 1 presents the path coefficients and *t* values for all of the hypotheses.

TABLE 1 Results of Path Analysis

Path Model	U.S. Sample			Chinese Sample		
	β	t	S/NS	β	t	S/NS
Hypothesized Relationship						
H1a Spirituality $\rightarrow$ Trust	.103	1.661	NS	.265	1.983	S
H1b Spirituality $\rightarrow$ Commitment	.360	4.306**	S	.468	4.507**	S
H2a Spirituality $\rightarrow$ Communication	.494	6.422**	S	.565	6.320**	S
H2b Spirituality $\rightarrow$ Shared Values	.226	3.015**	S	.496	4.511**	S
H2c Spirituality $\rightarrow$ Opportunism	-.073	-0.775	NS	-.008	-0.061	NS
Control Variables						
Communication $\rightarrow$ Trust	.276	3.801**		-.052	-0.423	
Communication $\rightarrow$ Commitment	.102	1.034		.110	1.145	
Shared Values $\rightarrow$ Trust	.193	2.743**		.224	1.896	
Shared Values $\rightarrow$ Commitment	.219	2.300*		.236	2.562**	
Opportunism $\rightarrow$ Trust	-.497	-8.931**		.047	0.457	
Opportunism $\rightarrow$ Commitment	-.089	-.1.173		.049	0.611	
Communication $\rightarrow$ Shared Values	.535	7.137**		.085	0.776	
Communication $\rightarrow$ Opportunism	-.325	-3.437**		.278	2.199*	
$\chi^2(df = 2)$	1.033 ^a			4.855 ^b		
Bentler-Bonett Normed Fit Index	.997			.967		
Comparative Fit Index	1.000			0.979		
Incremental Fit Index	1.003			0.980		
SRMR	.011			.042		

Notes: S = supported; NS = not supported; SRMR = standardized root-mean-square residual.

^a $p = .60$.

^b $p = .088$.

* $p < .05$

** $p < .01$

RESULTS

U.S. Sample Results

Maximum likelihood was used to estimate the path model. The chi-square test was not significant, $\chi^2(2) = 1.033$, $p > .05$, indicating a good fit. Additional model fit indices also suggested a good fit of the model (BBNFI = .997, CFI = 1.000, IFI = 1.003, standardized root-mean-square residual [SRMR] = .011; Bagozzi & Yi, 1988). These results combined indicated that the path model provided an acceptable fit and that the path coefficients could be used to test the related research hypotheses. To do this, we examined the sign and significance of the path coefficients in the fitted path model.

Our findings regarding the U.S. sample indicated no significant positive relationship between spirituality and trust, but a significant positive relationship was found between spirituality and commitment ($\beta = .360$, $p < .05$); hence, H1b was supported and H1a was not. Our findings also indicated significant positive relationships between spirituality and communication ($\beta = .494$, $p < .01$) and spirituality and shared values ($\beta = .226$, $p < .05$); hence, H2a and H2b were also supported. A negative but nonsignificant

relationship between spirituality and opportunism was found ($\beta = -.073$, $p > .05$); hence, H2c was not supported.

Though the relationships among the relational antecedents and trust/commitment were not formally hypothesized, they were included in the analysis. Significant positive relationships were found in the U.S. data between communication and trust ($\beta = .276$, $p < .05$), shared values and trust ($\beta = .193$, $p < .05$), shared values and communication ($\beta = .535$, $p < .01$), and shared values and commitment ($\beta = .219$, $p < .05$). In addition, significant negative relationships existed between opportunism and trust ($\beta = -.497$, $p < .05$) and opportunism and communication ($\beta = -.325$, $p < .05$); however, no significant relationship was found between opportunism and commitment. With the exception of this last finding, these results are overall consistent with previous conclusions in the extant literature.

Chinese Sample Results

The chi-square test was not significant, $\chi^2(2) = 4.855$, $p > .05$, indicating a good fit. The model fit indices also indicated a good fit (BBNFI = .967, CFI = .979, IFI = .980, SRMR = .042; Bagozzi & Yi, 1988).

In contrast to the results for the U.S. sample, we did find support for the hypothesized positive relationship between spirituality and trust ($\beta = .265$, $p < .05$). Consistent with the U.S. results, we also found support for the hypothesized positive relationship between spirituality and commitment ($\beta = .468$, $p < .05$); hence, both H1a and H1b were supported. Similarly, our findings indicated significant positive relationships between spirituality and communication ($\beta = .565$, $p < .01$) and spirituality and shared values ($\beta = .496$, $p < .01$); hence, H2a and 2b were also supported. H2c (a negative relationship between spirituality and opportunism) was not supported, but the relationship was in the direction theorized.

Regarding the controlled effect of relational antecedents on trust and commitment, the results for the Chinese sample were contrary to what the literature would suggest. Overall, we found only two significant links among those variables: a positive relationship between shared values and commitment ($\beta = .236$, $p < .05$) and a *positive* (opposite of our expectation) relationship between communication and opportunism ($\beta = .278$, $p < .05$). Furthermore, a surprising finding indicated *positive* (albeit not significant) relationships between opportunism and trust and between opportunism and commitment for the Chinese sample. These findings run mostly counter to what would be expected from the previous research and illustrate cross-cultural differences between the U.S. and Chinese participant groups.

In summary, for the U.S. data, we found support for three of the five relationships hypothesized. Though we did not find support for the effect of spirituality on trust and opportunism, the relationship was in the direction hypothesized. For the Chinese data, we found support for four out of the

five relationships hypothesized, with the exception of the spirituality–opportunism link.

Mediating Analyses

Because the effect of spirituality on trust is one of the major focuses of our current study and we found significant results for the Chinese sample but not for the U.S. sample, additional analyses were performed to further explore the possible mechanisms accounting for the mixed results. One potential explanation could be due to the different mediating mechanisms played by relational antecedents such as communication, shared values, and opportunism. Using hierarchical regression analyses, we tested the mediation effects following the methodology delineated by Baron and Kenny (1986). A significant relationship was first established between spirituality and trust for both samples. Then we confirmed that significant relationships existed between spirituality and the three relational variables in our model (shared values, opportunism, and communication). Such was the case for the U.S. data; however, for the Chinese data, only shared values and communication had a significant relationship with trust. Finally, trust was regressed upon spirituality and each relational mediating variable that had met the prerequisite conditions. Table 2 presents our results.

TABLE 2 Results of Hierarchical Regression Analyses

Path	<i>F</i>	<i>R</i> ²	<i>B</i>
U.S. data (<i>N</i> = 136)			
Spirituality → Trust	36.49***	.219	.677
Spirituality → Shared Values	41.98***	.247	.652
Spirituality & Shared Values → Trust	35.07**	.356	.339
			.487
Spirituality → Opportunism	9.15**	.066	–.482
Spirituality & Opportunism → Trust	80.07***	.554	.455
			–.461
Spirituality → Communication	39.29***	.233	.514
Spirituality & Communication → Trust	44.58**	.411	.312
			.695
Chinese data (<i>N</i> = 104)			
Spirituality → Trust	22.56***	.192	.688
Spirituality → Shared Values	36.80***	.286	.930
Spirituality & Shared Values → Trust	14.66**	.244	.451
			.244
Spirituality → Opportunism	1.10	.012	.168
Spirituality → Communication	40.07***	.303	.844
Spirituality & Communication → Trust	7.72	.145	.609
			–.089

Notes: Values are unstandardized coefficients.

p* ≤ .01, *p* ≤ .001.

It is notable that the results of our path analyses and the previous mediating analyses differed somewhat with regard to the relationships between spirituality and trust and spirituality and opportunism in the U.S. sample. Typically, the results of path analyses and hierarchical regression analyses will be fairly consistent; however, because they use different estimation methods, it is not unusual for differences in the results to appear. For example, the t value of the relationship between spirituality and trust in the path analysis was 1.661, which is very close to 1.96, the cutoff point for $p < .05$. Thus, the significant finding of the hierarchical regression analysis is understandable.

Our findings indicated that all three relational variables partially mediated the link between spirituality and trust for the U.S. sample. In contrast, only shared values appeared to partially mediate the spirituality–trust relationship for the Chinese sample.

DISCUSSION

In this study, we examined spirituality within the context of RM and studied the impact of spirituality upon the perceptions of trust and commitment within a cross-cultural context. Here we summarize our findings.

To begin, our study extends previous RM research by illustrating spirituality's effect on the perceptions and possible behaviors of buyers within these interorganizational contexts. For U.S. participants, spirituality was positively and significantly related to communication and shared values; there was also a direct, significant relationship to commitment, demonstrating the role spirituality plays in influencing the way in which buyers perceive their interactions with sellers. For Chinese buyers, spirituality appeared to have a similar relationship to commitment, shared values, and communication as for their U.S. counterparts; hence, there were some similarities across cultures with regard to spirituality.

However, although spirituality had a significant, direct, and positive effect on trust for Chinese participants, this effect was not significant for U.S. participants in our path modeling analyses. Our mediating analyses provided further clarification of the nature of this difference. There appeared to be a more direct effect between spirituality and trust for our Chinese participants than for our U.S. participants. Specifically, for the U.S. sample, the effect between spirituality and trust was significantly mediated by relational constructs. A clear reason for this is not evident, but we suspect it has to do with cultural differences in the roles of religion versus spirituality. In the United States, there is a history of separation of church and state, and that separation extends in large part to the business world. This explains in part why the idea of workplace spirituality is a relatively new concept in the West and is hard for some Western managers to embrace. Spirituality affects trust in a

more indirect way (as our model seems to indicate) through communication in positive ways, creation of shared values, and resisting of opportunistic behavior (as our mediating analyses would appear to suggest). The Chinese, in contrast, have a recent history of not acknowledging formalized religion, and yet theirs is a very spiritual culture with an emphasis on interconnectedness and relationships. Thus, spirituality and trust could be perceived as intimately entwined with each other, which also seems to be supported by our results.

Our analyses of relational antecedents, although not part of the formal hypotheses, revealed some interesting cultural differences as well. Although some relationships appeared to be similar between the two cultural samples (e.g., the significant positive relationship between shared values and commitment), others were not (e.g., relationships between shared values and trust and between shared values and communication were significant for U.S. participants but not for the Chinese). The findings regarding opportunism in the Chinese sample were both unexpected and interesting. Specifically, a *positive* (albeit not significant) relationship was found between opportunism and trust, and a *positive and significant* relationship was found between communication and opportunism.

These findings may be due to differences between the cultures as to what constitutes actual “opportunism” in a business context. It should be noted that both U.S. and Chinese cultures consider opportunism to be negative and a “violat[ion] of the norms of reciprocal relationships” (Lee et al., 2001, p. 51). However, what constitutes such opportunistic behavior might differ between Western and Chinese cultures. Our measure for opportunism focused on the alteration of facts and the extent to which promises are broken. According to our findings, U.S. participants consider these actions to be negative, constituting the Western view of opportunism. In contrast, our Chinese participants appear to view these actions as reasonable during *business* relationship building and maintenance.

This view of opportunism is evident within the social, economic, and cultural systems of China. As members of a low-trust country, Chinese people usually do not feel a strong degree of trust and/or emotional attachment to people with whom they have *instrumental* ties, as they view such ties as temporary and utilitarian based (Wang, 2007). This increases the chance of exploitation in business relationships with out-group members; in fact, the belief that business relations are essentially opportunistic is evident in the ancient Chinese saying “Among 10 businesspeople, 9 of them are double-dealing.” Given this, there is an established perspective that business people expect to exploit their partners and to be exploited by their partners during the relationship formation process (A. Wong et al., 2005). This may explain why opportunism did not result in significant negative outcomes in the Chinese sample. This represents an interesting area for future research.

Theoretical Implications

To study spirituality is to study an intangible, highly personal, very abstract concept. That said, we believe spirituality can (and should) be studied in much the same way as other intangible concepts in organizational research, such as leadership and power. Theoretically, we consider spirituality from an *integrative* perspective, as delineated in Giacalone and Jurkiewicz (2003). That is, we view spirituality as connected to the workplace, capable of exhibiting causal relationships with other work-related constructs. Hence, we focus on potential outcomes generated by individual spirituality within and upon workplace contexts.

This study provides a further glimpse into the individuals charged with making marketing relationships successful. Specifically, our findings provide insight into the buyer's mindset and predisposition concerning spirituality, which indirectly affect relational constructs such as trust and commitment. Hence, our results suggest that spirituality has an impact on individual buyer behavior in these relationships. This has implications for the way in which these buyers perceive and perform their work within marketing relationships. For instance, buyers who consider their work as a path toward a fulfilling inner life and meaningful purpose may put forth greater effort in relationship building than buyers who see their work only from a monetary perspective (i.e., an extrinsic motivator; Giacalone & Jurkiewicz, 2003).

The participants surveyed represented only buyers; because of this, we cannot state definitively that their seller counterparts would provide identical responses. However, we do theorize that the effect of spirituality on seller representatives will be similar to the results we found with buyers. Both buyers and sellers are working within the same environmental context, experiencing similar boundary-spanning situational factors.

Our study also contributes through its cross-cultural nature. These results support the idea of studying spirituality cross-culturally, given the similarities and differences in individual-level perceptions found between these two cultural samples. Likewise, we have demonstrated that relationships between established RM variables such as shared values and opportunism differ across these cultures. As RM moves increasingly into a global context, it is important to know how relationships among these RM variables might vary across global regions.

Managerial Implications

As stated previously, although organizations as a whole play an important role in RM, it is primarily the boundary-spanning buyers and sellers who form and maintain these relationships. It is crucial, therefore, that managers understand this and select these representatives with careful consideration of factors that influence the effectiveness of individuals in these roles. Our

study demonstrates that the spirituality of buyers influences key constructs in the relationship formation process. Some researchers have begun to use the term *spiritual activities* to describe spiritually oriented behaviors and mindsets. These activities include going beyond personal self-interest, acting with integrity, using spiritual resources to problem solve, and working to build collaborative and mutually beneficial partnerships (Emmons, 2000; George, 2006; Giacalone & Jurkiewicz, 2003). Because of the nature of such activities, we suggest that their effect will be more influential in ongoing, long-term relationships than in single-transaction exchanges; however, we are not in a position to make a definitive statement to that effect at this point.

These results also have implications for the sellers who work as counterparts to these buyers in marketing relationships. As suggested by Kurth (2003), individuals who have an awareness of and appreciation for the kind of connection possible with people who exhibit spiritual “cues” may act in ways that resonant with these individuals. By so doing, there are opportunities for increased trust, honesty, and reciprocity. Other researchers (Lehtonen, 2006; Swan & Nolan, 1985) have also emphasized the effect a representative’s behavior and attitude can have on developing trust and successful collaborative relationships. To put it in this context, if sellers exhibit behaviors and attitudes that are in line with those of their “spiritual” colleagues, this should increase the likelihood of trust building and relationship strengthening. The spiritual activities mentioned earlier are examples of ways in which sellers can build a connection. Displaying openness and engaging in frequent, meaningful communication are other ways to create this link. For managers, this further supports the notion of encouraging long-term (vs. transaction-based) relationships with organizational partners, to allow buyers and sellers to initiate and demonstrate the kind of attitude and behaviors indicative of this spiritual mindset.

Our findings also indicate that it would be useful to evaluate the extent of prospective buyers and sellers’ spirituality along with other individual-level dimensions during the selection process. In fact, we feel our findings have implications for managers in the process of recruiting, selecting, and maintaining personnel in the roles of both buyer and seller. For example, companies may benefit from keeping individuals in place rather than rotating through different buyers/sellers in order for the individual-level effect of a person’s spiritual intelligence to be fully realized. Furthermore, managers may consider the extent to which potential hires for these positions exhibit situational awareness, empathy, and self-awareness—characteristics that better equip a person to perceive and act on spiritual cues from others. Moreover, if spirituality does play a role in successful relationship formation, organizations might consider instigating policies that promote or sustain the spirituality of their employees in general and marketing representatives in particular.

Finally, our cross-cultural findings provide insight into similarities and differences between U.S. and Chinese perceptions of spirituality and other RM variables that might affect international RM efforts.

Limitations

The cross-sectional nature of the study limits our ability to capture the occurrence of some of the constructs used in the study because of our inability to represent the possible changes in effects over time; thus, longitudinal research may be desired to delve deeper into relationship development and maintenance. Furthermore, our framework focused on only one side's perspective (that of the buyer); future studies could seek to capture dyadic data within specific marketing relationships. Qualitative data regarding the buyer–seller relationship would help in demonstrating convergent validity. This research also relied on a single information source, and although statistical methods were used to control for this potential problem, common method bias is still possible.

Despite the cross-cultural nature of our study, we acknowledge that our spirituality measure stemmed from a Western perspective. It would be interesting to conduct a similar study among U.S. and Chinese buyers/sellers using a spirituality measure of Eastern orientation. In addition, some researchers have pointed out that Asian cultures stress modesty and humility, which might affect the degree to which Chinese respondents attribute socially desirable characteristics to themselves (Chiu & Yang, 1987; Ho & Ho, 2007).

Directions for Future Research

There are a variety of ways in which future research can be extrapolated from our results, particularly with regard to cross-cultural aspects. As mentioned earlier, our study focused solely on the spiritual perspective of buyer representatives, which is only one side of the dyad. Future work could attempt to match the spirituality of the buyer and seller. To what extent does the similarity (or dissimilarity) of the buyer and seller on the dimensions of spirituality influence the relationship formation process? The cross-cultural effects of both spirituality and RM in general also warrant more research from a business-to-business perspective. For instance, our study did not target buyer–seller relationships that consisted of international partners; how might the differences we found between cultures manifest and/or impact such relationships? Furthermore, can researchers better explain the difference across cultures in the influence of spirituality by interjecting Hofstede and/or other cross-cultural theoretical paradigms? In terms of generalizability,

subsequent studies could attempt to extend our findings to other countries as well. Finally, the difference found between the U.S. and China regarding opportunism is noteworthy and deserves further investigation.

Future research might explore the impact of spirituality within other interorganizational relationships, such as strategic alliances. Often, interorganizational management teams maintain and manage such alliances; how might the spirituality of these team members affect team effectiveness or the alliance as a whole? The effect of employee "spiritual" behavior within other stakeholder relationships also warrants further study. Subsequent research might also explore the relationship between spirituality and ethics in relationships among organizations.

Conclusion

Individual RM representatives play a crucial role in establishing and maintaining successful marketing relationships. Because of this, it is important to recognize and understand the impact of the individual-level aspects of these people. In our study, we identified one such aspect, spirituality, and examined how it affects trust and commitment in marketing relationships as well as how it relates to other antecedents established in the RM literature. We also conducted our study within a cross-cultural context in order to provide insight into the similarities and differences of spirituality and other relational antecedents between distinctly different cultures. It is our hope that our findings will generate further interest and examination of spirituality in interorganizational relationships as well as stimulate future studies of the phenomenon from a cross-cultural perspective.

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APPENDIX

Sample Survey Items (by Construct)

**A full version of the survey is available upon request.*

A 6-point Likert scale was used, anchored by strongly disagree/strongly agree.

Spirituality

(Adapted from Ashmos & Duchon, 2000; Milliman et al., 2003)

1. My work involving this relationship energizes my spirit.
2. I see a connection between my work on this relationship and the larger good.
3. My spiritual values influence the choices I make about this relationship.
4. My work for this relationship does not give meaning to me personally or professionally. (Reverse-scored)

Trust

(From Morgan & Hunt, 1994)

1. In this relationship, the other party has high integrity.
2. In this relationship, the other party can be counted on to do what is right.

Commitment

(From Morgan & Hunt, 1994)

1. The relationship that my firm has with this company is something we are very committed to.
2. The relationship that my firm has with this company deserves our firm's maximum effort to maintain.

Communication

(From Sin et al., 2002)

1. We can communicate honestly with one another.
2. We communicate and express our opinions to each other.

Shared Values

(From Sin et al., 2002)

1. We share the same feelings towards things around us.
2. We share the same values.

Opportunism

(From John, 1984)

1. To accomplish their own objectives, sometimes the other firm alters facts slightly.
2. To accomplish their own objectives, sometimes the other firm promises to do things without actually doing them.